

interface devices), these PCs are for those looking at something really simple yet attractive. It's a pity the chassis itself has a few sharp edges, as our fingers ruefully discovered.

Acer's Aspire IE3214 doesn't look radically different either. The cabinet appears to be as well built as the Intex cabinets—a knuckle rap on the side panel will give you some (not so good) vibes. Both Intex and Acer ship their products with 19-inch monitors, but the ultra-slim bezel on the Acer 19-inch widescreen really sets it apart visually. The Intex 19-inch LCD, in comparison, looks too bulky and rounded, with too large a bezel.

The Presario SG3053IL is another plain looker—nothing special here, and the cabinet is tinny (rap it with your knuckles and you'll figure!). HCL touts the EzeeBee Max XP Z999 as a value offering, and that shows. The cabinet build is a little better than that of the Presario, but that's not saying a great deal.

Incidentally, all the three Intex PCs have excellent expandability, with loads of space for installing additional hard drives and CD drives. The motherboards are pretty expandable too—four SATA ports and an x16 PCI Express slot. The Aspire IE3214 has a total of three PCI slots.

Hey! Where'd it go?

We were surprised to see an extremely rich software bundle with the Acer IE3214. A carton inside the main box contained a set of 11 CDs and DVDs. The contents ranged from games to movies, recipes, utilitarian software and even an encyclopaedia. Intex was not to be left behind and bundled Red Hat Enterprise Desktop Version 4 with each PC. A couple of useful software were also found in the DVD writing software disc. Intex provided both Windows XP and Vista drivers—a definite plus point.

The usual cables and other paraphernalia were also provided by all vendors—something that is typically overlooked in this category. None of the vendors provide wireless keyboards or mice. Shockingly, no speakers are provided either! You'll need to invest at least in a pair of headphones for any kind of aural experience on any of these desktop PCs.

Intex was thoughtful enough to provide dust covers for the entire PC with all three models—something Acer missed out on.

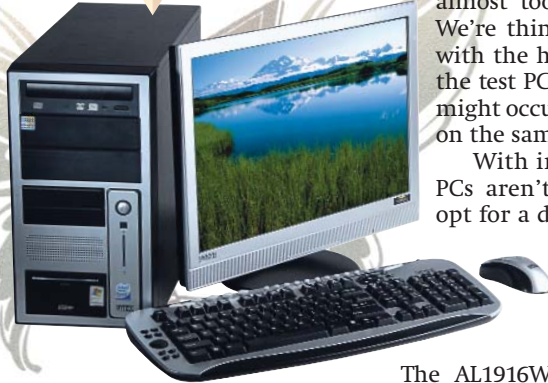
The EzeeBee Max XP Z999 comes with a pair of supraaural headphones (meaning they partially cover your ears).

Performance *Clash of the Tortoises!*

All these PCs are Intel-processor-powered. The newer budget Core 2 Duo processors (the E4x00 family) are fast, but not as fast in terms of clock speeds as the older Pentium D 925, which runs at a whopping 3 GHz on the Intex BF-73411—the fastest CPU (in terms of clock speeds) here. Heat could have become an issue, but the cabinet has sufficient vents to allow dissipation.

The Core 2 Duos in these PCs belong to the 4x00 and 2xx0 family. These are basically

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Intex BM-45431
A value-for-money performer

stripped-down Core 2 Duos and their performance is around the same as that of the older Pentium D—with a lot less heat, of course. Incidentally, one of the areas where the Pentium D runs out of steam is while watching HD movies—our test 1080p clip experienced some stuttering on the Intex BF-73411. No such issues on the other three. The BF-73411 has another issue: its hard drive is very slow—in fact, almost too slow for a SATA drive. We're thinking this was a problem with the hard drive that came with the test PC, and not something that might occur with another hard drive on the same make and model.

With integrated graphics, these PCs aren't for gamers—unless you opt for a discrete graphics card. All four PCs have PCI Express x16 slots, so you can opt to upgrade to a discrete graphics solution.

The AL1916W monitor bundled with the Acer Aspire IE3214 is much better than the monitor provided by Intex (all three Intex Desktops have the same monitor). HCL also provides a good 19-inch widescreen. All the vendors are pretty stingy with storage space, with the exception of the Intex BM-45431, which has a 250 GB hard drive.

Conclusion

Have I made the right choice?

Intex's BM-45431 is our *Best Buy Gold* winner—good specifications, a large hard drive and great expansion possibilities. Intex's warranty will also keep you happy—one-year on-site support is available, after which you'll get another two years of carry-in support. This PC makes a good choice for someone looking for an affordable yet fully-functional Desktop. It's quite powerful too, and also a decent multimedia performer; how we wish Intex had bundled a widescreen monitor!

We're awarding a joint Silver to Acer's superb Aspire IE3214 and HCL's EzeeBee Max XP Z999: their scores just too close to make a decision one way or

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Acer Aspire IE3214
Whatta bundle!